The seven classes are:

(1) The Bhamptas of the Deccan
(2) The Ina Koravars, alias Alagaries, of southern India
(3) The Bharwars of Gonda and Lallatpur
(4) The Mullahs of Muttra
(5) The Bhatrajas or Bhattu Turakas of India
(6) The Takku Woddars or Guntichores of southern India
(7) The railway pickpockets of India

He also added the ‘Indian railway servant’ to the list, who proved to be a nuisance to the authorities. The methods of most of the railway thieves are very similar, varying only slightly in detail .

The first three classes mentioned are the experts at this kind of crime.

The Bhamptas are the most determined and irreclaimable thieves and pickpockets. They are gregarious, and operate in gangs or combinations. They are good linguists, and they so arrange the use of their different languages that they invariably contrive to adopt a language alien to the district wherein they are pursuing their nefarious calling. Thus, when they are engaged in the Telugu districts, they talk in Mahratti and Canarese; when in Mahratti and Canarese countries they talk in Telugu. They also have a secret code of words and phrases of their own. They rarely resort to any form of violence, relying for success solely upon their skill, subtlety and dexterity.

The Koravars are Sivavites in religion, and wear a horizontal mark of ash on their foreheads as the distinguishing mark of their sect. Their methods are much the same as those of the Bhamptas. They enlist juvenile aid, employing their own or purchased children in the service of their nefarious calling. Having accomplished a theft on a train, they will alight at a station and hide in the latrine until the train has resumed its journey. If they should be thus found and suspected, they will declare they have inadvertently lost the train, express their dismay, and even shed bitter tears.

The Bharwars are a criminal fraternity who engage in picking pockets at bathing-ghauts, fairs, festivals, choultries and railway stations, moving about all over India, often disguised as fakirs.

The Bhatrajas are most unscrupulous in their methods. One one occasion, for instance, a member of a gang helped a Brahmin with his luggage, and then helped himself to one of the bags.

One of the strategic devices adopted by the tribe of Mullahs is for a member of the gang, disguised as a fakir, to sit and smoke in the passenger hall of a railway station. Other members of the gang come up to him, although they put up a show of being strangers to him, and he presents them with a free smoke. This generosity being observed by passengers, they gather round to enjoy the same privilege and end up getting relieved of their portable possessions.

The railway servants themselves also commit thefts and give the authorities a great deal of trouble. Guards, porters and even station masters engage in these thefts, mostly of goods in transit. [111]